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Reportative parentheticals and Common Ground

Plausible deniability and discourse commitments

1 Goals & research questions

- Reportatives attribute a proposition to an external source, as a type of evidential (Aikhenvald 2018).

(1) John said that it will rain tomorrow.

- Reportative parentheticals (a.k.a. *slifting parentheticals* Ross 1973; Koev 2021, 2022) are set off prosodically from the proposition and are not syntactically embedding.

(2) It will rain tomorrow, John said.

- The speaker avoids comitting to the proposition and merely entertains it (Jackendoff 2025).
- Depending on the source, reportatives are used as *figleaves* (Saul 2024) to cover up controversial claims.

Research questions:

- Do reportatives decrease the speaker's trustworthiness?
- Does the position of a reportative (embedding vs. parenthetical) have an effect on the degree of speaker trustworthiness?

2 Theoretical background

- Assumption: in assertions, the speaker is committed to the truth of the proposition and is socially responsible for it (Searle 1969; Krifka 2021, 2023).

3 Experimental design

- 1×3 design: no reportative vs. embedding reportative vs. parenthetical reportative.
- Embedded in a discourse context that introduces a speaker *Mary*, who talks about mutual friends.
- Question: how trustworthy is Mary as a speaker?
- Participants rate Mary's trustworthiness on a 7-point Likert scale.

(3) a. Peter bought a new sports car last week.
[no reportative]

b. John said Peter bought a new sports car last week.
[embedding reportative]

c. Peter bought a new sports car last week, John said.
[parenthetical reportative]

Hypotheses:

- The presence of a reportative decreases speaker trustworthiness.
- The position of a reportative (embedding vs. parenthetical) has an effect on the degree of speaker trustworthiness.

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